

What's your view on the environmental impact of AI tools like ChatGPT?

Posted by u/ReadySteadyXL • 0 points • 13 comments

This topic comes up a lot in my tech-adoption sessions, and I'd love to hear how this community sees it. There's plenty of debate around energy use, carbon footprint, and whether the overall impact of AI is a genuine concern or sometimes overstated.

****What's your take on the environmental impact of AI?****

Curious to hear a mix of perspectives.

Comments

u/Golden_Apple_23 • 2 points • 2026-01-29 14:38 UTC

There's greater carbon footprint and water use with cattle farming. The problem with energy use is reliance on fossil fuels and it seems the bigger players in AI are looking at nuclear and renewables as major supplements to current energy production.

u/DBCooper211 • -1 points • 2026-01-29 14:29 UTC

Anyone that thinks cow farts are worse than data centers and cell phones is a brainwashed narcissist.

u/bacon_cake • 3 points • 2026-01-29 12:16 UTC

It's really hard for me to take people seriously when they worry about other people's AI water usage and they won't even stop eating meat.

I don't eat meat, I'm not that militant about it, and in general I hate whataboutism, but people so concerned about the water-usage-AI thing baffles me when they chomp up every other water using vice out there.

u/theirongiant74 • 1 points • 2026-01-29 12:01 UTC

The reality is that humanity is not going to choose regress to some 1800s agrarian society, capitalism is going to keep pushing us forward and the only hope we have is that science and tech can get in front of it before the bill becomes due.

u/Big-Tutor-3060 • 2 points • 2026-01-29 11:53 UTC

The lifecycle process of gasoline is pretty terrible for the environment and the people involved, and you're a lot closer to having alternate cooling options for data centers than an less impactful fuel source for internal combustion engines.

u/Shrike034 • 0 points • 2026-01-29 11:41 UTC

Not environmental but AI has pretty much screwed over the gaming hobby so I tend to refrain.

u/Golden_Apple_23 • 1 points • 2026-01-29 14:41 UTC

And that's not on AI. That's on capitalism prioritizing greater profits of enterprise-focused manufacturing and not consumer-based.

u/U1ahbJason • 4 points • 2026-01-29 11:40 UTC

There is an impact that's undeniable, but it's very hard for someone to preach about the environmental impact of AI and not be concerned about the environmental impact of red meat production or the amount of water used in the production of corn for ethanol or the near slave labor used to create smart phones. We're all guilty of those things and I'm not saying "what aboutism" i'm saying you can't selectively choose your outrage without looking at your own footprint. I'm saying those without dog shit on their sneaker take the first step on the white carpet. Yes, I miss quoting Whoopi Goldberg. 🤔

u/Komi29920 • 1 points • 2026-03-01 11:39 UTC

Late reply but someone in a Discord server I'm on got mad a few days ago when I mentioned factory farming in a DIFFERENT CONTEXT (the AI discussion had ended). They heavily implied that they don't care about factory farming. That's where I lost respect, as there was no consistency whatsoever. At least be consistent and oppose both AI and the modern meat industry!

u/Individual_Dog_7394 • 3 points • 2026-01-29 11:38 UTC

My take is, literally everything we use is terrible for the environment, starting from animal products.

u/Initial-Tale-5151 • 8 points • 2026-01-29 11:33 UTC

The separation of AI water use from using reddit, sending an email or watching Youtube shows what it's about. A bunch of babies who hate AI pulling out whatever argument they think will help them win an argument and feel like they are good people.

Tech uses water. All the people griping don't care about the water use for the tech they want to use.

People are just irrational losers and AI is the latest thing for them to freak out about

u/ArborealLife • 8 points • 2026-01-29 11:30 UTC

Isn't it no different from watching Netflix or YouTube?

u/ReadySteadyXL • 1 points • 2026-01-29 11:59 UTC

Good point! I might say this next time the topic comes up in my sessions

u/AutoModerator • 1 points • 2026-01-29 11:27 UTC

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If your post is a DALL-E 3 image post, please reply with the prompt used to make this image.

Consider joining our [public discord server](<https://discord.gg/r-chatgpt-1050422060352024636>)! We have free bots with GPT-4 (with vision), image generators, and more!

🤖

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